

Imperial China

China is one of the world's oldest civilizations, having lasted more than 4,000 years. It was an empire from 221 BCE until 1912, making it the longest-lasting empire in history.

THE GREAT WALL

The final version of the Wall, built during the Ming dynasty to keep China's northern enemies out, was around 8,850 km (5,500 miles) long.



ANCIENT WONDERS

The empire, with its vast wealth, technological skills, and unlimited manpower, created some of the biggest and most magnificent works of engineering and architecture ever made.



FORBIDDEN CITY
Enormous palace and fortress built in Beijing from 1406–21.



TERRACOTTA ARMY
8,000 life-size statues, buried along with Emperor Qin Shi Huang.

GREAT EMPERORS

Some strong emperors had long reigns, but many emperors were deposed or assassinated. At times, China was split among warring emperors.

- **QIN SHI HUANG (QIN DYNASTY, 259–210 BCE)**
He conquered neighbouring states to become the first emperor of a unified China and founder of the Qin Dynasty.
- **HAN WUDI (HAN DYNASTY, 156–87 BCE)**
Seventh emperor of the Han, he ruled for 54 years. During his reign, China's wealth and territory increased.
- **WU ZETIAN (TANG DYNASTY, 624–705 CE)**
China's only female emperor. She was the wife of Emperor Gaozong, and took over from him when he became ill. Eventually, she declared herself China's sole ruler.
- **YONGLE (MING DYNASTY, 1360–1424)**
The third Ming emperor, known for his ruthlessness and cruelty. He moved the Chinese capital from Nanjing to Beijing and built the Forbidden City.
- **KANGXI (QING DYNASTY, 1654–1722)**
The longest-reigning emperor; he took the throne at the age of eight. His 61-year rule was a time of peace and prosperity for China.

EMPEROR YONGLE



GREAT INVENTIONS

Some of the world's greatest inventions and discoveries came from Imperial China, and many of those inventions are still in use today. Scientists and engineers were highly valued by the emperors.



SILK
c.4000 BCE



SHIP'S RUDDER
c.100 CE

WRITING

Writing by hand was considered an art form in China. It took calligraphers (professional hand-writers) years to learn how to make the 40,000 characters they needed to write the language.



CALLIGRAPHY SET

INK

THE DEVELOPMENT OF WRITING

Chinese characters have been simplified over their 4,000 years of use.

	HUMAN	WOMAN	HORSE	MOUNTAIN
ORACLE BONE 14th–11th century BCE	人	女	馬	山
CLERICAL SCRIPT (LISHU) c.300 BCE	人	女	馬	山
MODERN SIMPLIFIED SCRIPT 1956	人	女	马	山

1650 BCE

RULING DYNASTIES

China was ruled by a series of dynasties, or families. Emperors were sometimes overthrown by rival clans or foreign invaders. When this happened, a new ruler took the throne and a new dynasty began.

SHANG
c.1650–1046 BCE
China's first great ruling dynasty.

c.1500 BCE
Craftsmen learn large-scale production of bronze weapons and tools.



Bronze wine beaker, Shang dynasty

c.1250 BCE
Earliest evidence of writing in China.

c.1046 BCE
The last Shang ruler is defeated at the Battle of Muye.



Rice pot, Zhou dynasty

ZHOU
c.1046–256 BCE
Feudal system begins: lords rule over the peasants who work on their estates.

WARRING STATES
481–221 BCE
As the Zhou decline, there is a period of struggle for control of China.

771 BCE
King You is killed and Haojing, the capital, is overrun by invaders. The Zhou court flees east.

551 BCE
Philosopher Confucius is born.



Confucius

QIN
221–207 BCE
China is united under one emperor.

221 BCE
Warrior Zheng declares himself Emperor Shi Huang, ruler of all China.

214 BCE
Construction begins on the Great Wall.



Building the Great Wall

HAN
207 BCE–220 CE
Civil service is established, which will run China for the next 2,000 years.

105 CE
An imperial court official reports the invention of paper.

c.250
Buddhism is introduced to China.

PERIOD OF DISUNITY
221–589
China is invaded and divides into separate states.

SUI
581–618
China is reunified.

618
China's golden age begins, a period of great artistic and scientific developments.



Horse figure, Tang dynasty

TANG
618–906
China expands to become a great world power.

FIVE DYNASTIES AND TEN KINGDOMS
907–960
China is once again divided into north and south.

1100
China's population grows to about 100 million.



Porcelain vase, Song dynasty

SONG
960–1279
Advances in technology bring wealth and prosperity.

1279
Mongol invaders, led by Kublai Khan, conquer China.



Mongol warrior

YUAN
1279–1368
The conquering Mongols establish their own dynasty.

MING
1368–1644
Exquisite art and crafts are produced throughout the period.

1420
Beijing is named as the new capital of China.



Plate, Ming dynasty

1839–1860
In the Opium Wars, China and Western nations battle over trade.

QING
1644–1912
The empire declines steadily and is eventually overthrown.

1912
2,000 years of imperial rule come to an end when six-year-old emperor, Puyi, is deposed.

1912